

THE OLYMPIC GOLD QUEST, SPEARHEADED BY PRAKASH PADUKONE AND GEET SETHI, FOCUSES ON TALENT IDENTIFICATION AND FUND-RAISING IN THE SEARCH FOR INDIA'S FIRST INDIVIDUAL OLYMPIC GOLD MEDALLIST.

Badminton

SAINA NEHWAL, 18

World junior finalist and the first Indian woman to win a world four-star event, Hyderabad's Nehwal is now ranked in the top 20 in the world.

"With a big sponsor behind me, I can play as many events as I want."

days later he emailed to say he had found the oco's bank account details on its website and deposited Rs 11 lakh into it. In the early days, Sethi believed collecting a few crores would be enough. Now he's thinking, "If we can raise Rs 100 crore, we could fund 100 athletes and find our gold medallist. We just need a rupee from every Indian." What elite athletes need, he insists, is a "massive injection" of funds to bridge the chasm between fifth and first. "Athletes can't be kept waiting. If they don't get the money when they need it, then it's of no use."

India's under-achievement around the Olympics rests on two pillars of rationalisation: funds and facilities. MCT's Malhotra believes Indian sport does not lack money, but expertise and planning. The Sports Ministry's spending in the last three years bears that out: between 2005-06 and 2007-08, the

ministry's National Sports Development Fund sanctioned Rs 3.05 crore to athletes for training and tournament expenses and released a further Rs 126.16 crore as assistance to national sports federations for their athletes. As for facilities, former Olympic swimmer S. Hakim Habibullah, also manager for Khade and fellow Olympic qualifier Sandeep Sejwal, points out that England has 16 50-m pools in the entire country; Bangalore itself has nine.

Aparna Popat, Commonwealth Games badminton medallist, and world juniors finalist, remembers her first Olympics well. A last minute entrant into Sydney 2000, she recalls the scramble for funds to play pre-Games events, approaching corporates and being told, "Assure us you'll get the gold." Instead of concentrating on final fine-tuning, athletes lived with the nagging worry that a rival had nailed a funding source which had escaped them.

The Games badminton team was a steaming pot of insecurity. Popat says, "You seldom got the feeling that you were playing for India on one team,



APARNA POPAT